IN MUMBAI, PIGEON-FEEDING SETS FAITH, ECOLOGY AND POLITICS ON A COLLISION COURSE. THE REAL WORRY, THOUGH, IS PUBLIC HEALTH



BHASKAR PAUL

BIRDS OF CONTENTION A file picture of pigeons being fed at the Gateway of India in Mumbai

↘ **Cryptococcosis:** A lung disease that targets the central nervous system, posing greater risk to people with weakened immunity

↘ **Psittacosis:** A bacterial infection from pigeons that can progress to pneumonia if left untreated

↘ **Allergies:** Pigeons can trigger allergic reactions in predisposed individuals

↘ **Asthma:** Repeated contact with feathers, droppings or dust can cause respiratory difficulties

↘ **Pigeon breeder's lung:** Also known as hypersensitivity pneumonitis, caused by inhaling fine dust particles from droppings, leading to lung inflammation

↘ **Parasitic infections:** Pigeons often carry mites, lice and fleas that spread into human surroundings, causing skin allergies, itching and secondary infections